

The Brass Automaton

Business Plan

A Steampunk Cocktail Bar with Robotic Bartenders and Live Music

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Confidential

1. Executive Summary

The Brass Automaton is a steampunk-themed cocktail bar planned for Shoreditch, London. It pairs robotic bartender technology with Victorian-industrial design, live jazz and swing music, and a tapas-style small plates menu. The concept sits in a gap that London's nightlife market has not filled. Themed bars are growing. Robotic service technology is maturing. Live music venues draw loyal crowds. But nothing in London puts all three together at an accessible price point.

The bar seats 100 to 130 guests across roughly 2,200 square feet. Two robotic bartender units mix cocktails behind brass and glass panels. Every drink order becomes a piece of theatre. Human staff in period costume handle hosting, table service, and food. Live jazz, swing, and acoustic acts perform Thursday through Saturday.

Revenue comes from four streams. Individual drink sales account for the majority. Tapas food orders add healthy margin. An unlimited drink package (called The Boiler Room) runs at £39 to £57 per person for 2 to 3 hours. Private event hire fills quieter periods.

The menu spans roughly 50 drinks across signature cocktails, classics, Martini and Negroni variations, vermouths, premium options, fancy and simple shots, mocktails, beers, wines, and soft drinks. Signature cocktails sit at £11 to £13, classics at £8 to £10. The pricing deliberately undercuts London's £13 average for cocktails while offering a premium experience. Food runs at £5 to £13 per plate, with 3 to 4 plates recommended per person.

Financial summary below.

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Revenue	£525,000	£770,000	£977,500
Cost of Goods Sold	£138,600	£203,280	£258,060
Operating Costs	£456,600	£475,000	£495,000
Net Profit (Loss)	(£70,200)	£91,720	£224,440
Avg Daily Covers	50	70	85
Break-even (monthly)	Month 7-8		

Total startup investment is approximately £320,000. That covers lease deposit, steampunk fitout, two robotic bartender units, initial stock, licensing, and three months of working capital.

2. Mission and Vision

Mission. To build a cocktail bar where technology, craftsmanship, and atmosphere work together to create something people remember. The Brass Automaton exists to prove that a night out can feel exclusive without being expensive, and that robots can make a bar more human, not less.

Vision. To become London's most distinctive cocktail bar within three years. To build a brand that people associate with inventive drinks, theatrical service, and a genuinely different night out. In the longer term, to prove the model works well enough to open a second location.

3. The Concept

The Brass Automaton combines four elements that do not currently exist together in London's bar scene.

First, the steampunk aesthetic. The interior draws from Victorian industrial design. Brass fittings, copper piping, exposed gears, Edison bulbs, antique maps, and retro-futuristic instruments fill the space. Staff wear period-inspired attire. The atmosphere is warm, theatrical, and deliberately analogue in feel, which makes the robotic element all the more striking.

Second, robotic bartenders. Two robotic cocktail-making units sit behind the main bar, enclosed in custom brass and glass housings. They mix, shake, pour, and garnish drinks with visible mechanical precision. The process takes 60 to 90 seconds per cocktail and is designed to be watched. This is not a vending machine. It is a performance.

Third, live music. Jazz, swing, and acoustic acts perform Thursday through Saturday evenings on a small raised stage. The music fits the era. It fills the room without dominating conversation. No cover charge. The cost is built into the operating model.

Fourth, the food and drink programme. A tapas-style menu of small plates complements the cocktails. The drinks menu runs deep, from house signatures and classics through Martini and Negroni variations, vermouths, premium pours, fancy shots, and a thoughtful mocktail selection. An unlimited drink package called The Boiler Room gives guests a fixed-price option for 2 to 3 hours.

The combination is the point. Themed bars exist. Robotic bars exist in airports and cruise ships. Jazz cocktail bars exist. But nobody in London has assembled all four into a single venue at accessible pricing.

4. The Problem

London's cocktail bar market is large and growing. The UK cocktail market is valued at roughly £587 million, with London accounting for a disproportionate share. The average cocktail in central London now costs £13, up 51p year on year. Consumers are spending more per visit, but they are also becoming more selective about where that money goes.

The problem is sameness. Walk through Shoreditch, Soho, or Dalston on a Friday night and the bars start to blend. Dark interiors, exposed brick, craft cocktails, the same playlist. The venues that stand out are the ones offering something genuinely different. Themed and immersive experiences (Mr Fogg's, Cahoots, The Bletchley) consistently outperform standard bars on bookings and social media engagement.

At the same time, robotic bartender technology has matured. Makr Shakr has seen a 72% rise in installations across cruise ships, airports, and luxury resorts globally. The global robotic bartender market was valued at \$1.8 billion in 2025 and is projected to reach \$5.6 billion by 2034. But almost none of this technology has reached London's independent bar scene. It remains trapped in corporate hospitality.

There is a clear gap. Consumers want experiences. The technology exists. Nobody has brought the two together in a London bar at a price point that feels accessible rather than exclusive.

5. Technology

The core technology is a pair of robotic cocktail-making units from an established manufacturer (Makr Shakr, KUKA, or equivalent). Each unit consists of a robotic arm capable of selecting bottles, measuring precise quantities, mixing, shaking, pouring, and garnishing. The units can produce a cocktail in 60 to 90 seconds with repeatable consistency.

The units will be housed in custom steampunk casings. Brass frames, copper accents, glass panels for visibility, and integrated steam effects for atmosphere. The housing is cosmetic and does not affect the mechanical operation. From the guest's perspective, the drink is being made by a Victorian automaton.

Each unit costs approximately £30,000 to £40,000, with the steampunk casing adding an estimated £5,000 to £8,000 per unit. Annual maintenance runs at roughly £3,000 per unit, covering servicing, calibration, and parts.

The robots handle all cocktail preparation. Human bar staff manage customer interaction, take orders via a POS system that feeds the robotic queue, handle non-cocktail drinks (beer pours, wine service), and step in for bespoke requests the robots cannot fulfil. This is not a fully automated bar. It is a bar where the robots handle the craft and the humans handle the hospitality.

Phase 2 of the technology plan (from Month 13 onwards) introduces robotic drink delivery. One or two service robots (similar to BellaBot units, at approximately £10,000 to £15,000 each) would carry finished drinks from the bar to tables. This is a novelty addition rather than a labour replacement, and will only be introduced once the core model is stable.

6. Menu and Pricing Strategy

The pricing philosophy is simple. Feel premium, stay accessible. London's average cocktail costs £13. The Brass Automaton's signature cocktails sit at £11 to £13. Classics run £8 to £10. That means a guest paying £11 for a Clockwork Negroni is getting a theatrically prepared drink in a fully immersive environment for less than the city average. The experience punches above the price.

The menu is structured in nine categories.

Signature Cocktails (£11 to £13)

Drink	Ingredients	Price
The Automaton	Gin, elderflower, cucumber, tonic foam	£12
Clockwork Negroni	Campari, sweet vermouth, gin, orange peel	£11
Steam Engine	Espresso, vodka, coffee liqueur, smoke bubble	£13
Copper Coil	Bourbon, honey, ginger, lemon	£11
The Piston	Rum, passion fruit, lime, vanilla	£12
Velvet Gear	Vodka, raspberry, Chambord, prosecco float	£12
The Furnace	Tequila, chilli, mango, lime	£11
Midnight Contraption	Dark rum, coffee liqueur, chocolate bitters, cherry	£13

Classic Cocktails (£8 to £10)

Drink	Price
Old Fashioned	£10
Mojito	£9

Margarita	£9
Whiskey Sour	£10
Daiquiri	£8
Gin & Tonic	£8
Moscow Mule	£9
Aperol Spritz	£9

Martinis and Negronis (£9 to £11)

Drink	Price
Classic Martini (gin or vodka)	£10
Espresso Martini	£11
Dirty Martini	£10
Lemon Drop Martini	£10
Pornstar Martini	£11
Classic Negroni	£10
Negroni Sbagliato	£10
Boulevardier	£10
White Negroni	£10

Vermouths on the Rocks (£6 to £7)

Drink	Price
Sweet Vermouth (Cocchi di Torino)	£7
Dry Vermouth (Noilly Prat)	£6
Rosso Vermouth (Punt e Mes)	£7
Bianco Vermouth (Lillet Blanc)	£7

Premium Shelf (£15 to £17)

Drink	Ingredients	Price
Japanese Highball	Suntory Toki, soda	£15
Aged Rum Manhattan	Aged rum, sweet vermouth, bitters	£16
Hendrick's Orbium Martini	Hendrick's Orbium, dry vermouth	£15
Woodford Reserve Old Fashioned	Woodford Reserve, sugar, bitters	£17

Fancy Shots (£5 to £7)

Shot	Ingredients	Price
Bullshot	Vodka, beef consommé, Worcestershire, lemon, Tabasco	£7
Kentucky Buck	Bourbon, strawberry, ginger, bitters	£6
Penicillin Shot	Scotch, honey, ginger, lemon	£6
Kamikaze	Vodka, triple sec, lime	£5

Simple Shots (£4 to £5)

Spirit	Price
Vodka	£4
Gin	£4

White Rum	£4
Tequila Blanco	£4
Whisky (house)	£5
Sambuca	£4
Jägermeister	£4

Beer and Cider (£5.50 to £6.50)

Drink	Price
Craft IPA (rotating)	£6.50
Craft Lager	£6.00
Premium Lager	£5.50
Craft Cider	£6.00
Stout	£6.50

Wine (£7 to £14 per glass)

Wine	Price
House Red	£7
House White	£7
Rosé	£7.50
Prosecco	£8
Champagne	£14

Mocktails (£5 to £6)

Drink	Ingredients	Price
Mocktail Automaton	Elderflower, cucumber, tonic water	£6
Mocktail Piston	Passion fruit, lime, vanilla soda	£6
Virgin Mojito	Lime, mint, soda, sugar	£5
Copper Sunset	Mango, ginger, lime, soda	£6
The Gearshift	Apple, mint, elderflower, sparkling water	£5
Brass Berry	Mixed berries, basil, lemonade	£6
Steam Cloud	Coconut, pineapple, lime, cream soda	£6

Soft Drinks (£3 to £4)

Drink	Price
Craft Sodas	£4
Fresh Juices	£4
Still / Sparkling Water	£3

Tapas Menu (£5 to £13 per plate)

Guests are encouraged to order 3 to 4 plates each. All food is served on steampunk-styled crockery, including gear-shaped copper trays, mini copper pots, and Victorian-era inspired plates. The presentation is part of the experience.

Dish	Price
Charcuterie Board (for 2)	£13

Bruschetta Trio	£6
Marinated Olives and Artichokes	£5
Smoked Salmon Crostini	£7
Copper Pot Fries (truffle, parmesan)	£6
Mini Wagyu Sliders (×3)	£9
Tempura King Prawns (×4)	£8
Arancini, mushroom and truffle (×3)	£7
Patatas Bravas	£5
Halloumi Fries	£6
Pulled Pork Croquettes (×4)	£7
Stuffed Peppers (×3)	£6
Churros and Chocolate	£6
Mini Crème Brûlée	£6

7. The Boiler Room (Unlimited Drink Package)

The Boiler Room is an unlimited drink package designed to fill seats on quieter nights and give groups a reason to book in advance. It works like the bottomless brunch model that London already understands, but adapted for an evening cocktail bar.

Duration	Monday to Thursday	Friday to Saturday
2 hours	£39 per person	£44 per person
3 hours	£52 per person	£57 per person

Minimum two people. Advance booking required. The package is deliberately limited to five cocktails, two beers, two wines, and soft drinks. The full menu is not included. That is by design.

Included drinks

Copper Coil (bourbon, honey, ginger, lemon), The Piston (rum, passion fruit, lime, vanilla), Velvet Gear (vodka, raspberry, Chambord, prosecco), Mojito, Aperol Spritz. Plus Craft Lager, Premium Lager, House Red, House White, and all soft drinks.

Excluded

All other signature cocktails (Automaton, Steam Engine, Clockwork Negroni, Furnace, Midnight Contraption), all Martini and Negroni variations, all vermouths, all Premium Shelf cocktails, Prosecco, Champagne, Craft IPA, Stout, Cider, and all shots.

The economics work well. An average guest drinks 4 to 5 drinks in 2 hours. At roughly £2.50 ingredient cost per drink, that is £10 to £12.50 in cost against £39 revenue. Gross margin sits at 68 to 74%. The limited selection also creates curiosity about the excluded signatures, which drives additional sales. And almost everyone on the package orders food.

8. Live Entertainment

Live music runs Thursday through Saturday evenings, starting at 8pm. The style is jazz, swing, and acoustic. That fits the Victorian-era aesthetic without overpowering conversation. There is no cover charge. The cost of music is built into the operating model.

Booking budget is £400 to £700 per evening for a 3 to 4 piece band, giving a monthly live music spend of roughly £5,500. PRS and PPL licensing adds approximately £1,200 per year. The stage area is small and raised, with vintage-looking equipment and warm lighting.

Live music serves three purposes. It gives the bar a genuine soul that playlists cannot replicate. It creates a reason to visit on specific nights rather than any night. And it generates social media content organically, since guests film and share performances without being asked.

9. Market Opportunity

The UK cocktail market is valued at approximately £587 million. London accounts for a disproportionate share of that figure. The average Londoner spends £30 to £50 on a night out at a cocktail bar. Consumer demand for experiential and immersive venues continues to grow, with themed bars consistently outperforming standard venues on bookings and repeat visits.

The robotic bartender market is expanding rapidly. Valued at \$1.8 billion globally in 2025, it is projected to reach \$5.6 billion by 2034, a compound annual growth rate of 13.5%. Makr Shkr alone saw a 72% increase in installations across cruise ships, airports, and luxury resorts. But this technology has barely touched independent bars in London. The market is ready. The supply is not there yet.

Shoreditch remains one of London's strongest markets for independent bars. The area attracts young professionals (25 to 40), tourists, and creatives who actively seek out distinctive venues. Footfall on weekend evenings is high, and the audience is receptive to novelty.

The addressable market for The Brass Automaton is Londoners and visitors willing to spend £30 to £60 on a distinctive night out. At 85 covers per day at steady state, the bar needs to capture a tiny fraction of that market. The opportunity is not about volume. It is about being memorable enough that the right 85 people choose this bar on any given night.

10. Competition

The competitive landscape splits into three categories.

Themed and immersive bars

Mr Fogg's (multiple locations) is the closest comparison in terms of atmosphere. Their venues are themed around Phileas Fogg and Victorian adventure, with elaborate decor, costumed staff, and inventive cocktails. They charge premium prices (£14 to £18 per cocktail). Mrs Fogg's Maritime Club includes a speakeasy and a working distillery. Cahoots (Soho) recreates a 1940s tube station. The Bletchley (Chelsea) uses a WWII code-breaking theme. Hokus Pokus runs an underground steampunk-adjacent apothecary bar. The Spirit of Man (War of the Worlds experience) is the only explicitly steampunk bar and restaurant in London.

None of these venues use robotic technology. None of them combine live music as a regular feature. And most of them price above the London average rather than at or below it.

Live music cocktail bars

Nightjar (Shoreditch) pairs jazz with cocktails and is regularly voted one of London's best bars. Kansas Smitty's (Hackney) is a dedicated jazz bar with a loyal following. Ronnie Scott's (Soho) is a

legendary jazz club at a higher price point. These venues prove the demand for live music and cocktails together. None of them offer robotic service or immersive theming.

Robotic bars

Robotic bartenders currently operate in airports, cruise ships (Royal Caribbean's Bionic Bar), and some hotel lobbies. There is no established robotic bar in London's independent bar scene. This is the gap.

The Brass Automaton's competitive advantage is the combination. Steampunk atmosphere, robotic bartenders, live music, tapas, and pricing that sits below the London cocktail average. No single competitor offers all five.

11. Location and Design

The target location is Shoreditch, East London. The area has the highest concentration of independent bars in London, a receptive audience for experiential venues, and strong weekend footfall. Secondary options include Camden (established nightlife, slightly lower rents) and Bermondsey (emerging bar scene, good transport links).

The venue needs approximately 2,000 to 2,500 square feet. That supports a capacity of 100 to 130 across a main bar area, a raised stage for live music, a semi-private area for group bookings, and a kitchen for tapas preparation. Estimated monthly rent in Shoreditch sits at £5,000 to £7,000 for this size.

Interior design draws from Victorian industrial aesthetics. Dark wood panelling, exposed brass piping, copper fixtures, Edison bulb lighting, vintage leather seating, gear and cog motifs, antique maps and scientific instruments on the walls, and retro-futuristic gadgets in display cases. The robotic bartender units sit behind the main bar in custom brass and glass housings, visible to the entire room. The stage area uses warm spotlighting and vintage-styled equipment. The overall effect should feel like stepping into an alternate-history London where steam power never gave way to electricity.

12. Revenue Model

Revenue comes from four sources. The split below is estimated for a steady-state month (Year 2 onwards).

Revenue Stream	Share of Revenue	Notes
Individual drink sales	55%	Cocktails, beer, wine, shots, soft drinks at menu prices
Food sales (tapas)	20%	70% of guests order food, avg 2 to 3 plates
Boiler Room packages	20%	Roughly 20% of covers book the unlimited option
Private events	5%	Group bookings, corporate events, hire on quieter nights

Average spend per cover is estimated at £42, split roughly £30 on drinks and £12 on food. Guests on The Boiler Room package spend £39 to £57 on drinks (depending on duration and day) plus food on top. The package drives higher overall spend per head because food ordering increases when guests feel their drinks are already covered.

13. Financial Projections

The financial model is built on conservative assumptions. The bar opens five days per week (Tuesday to Saturday), giving 250 operating days per year. Covers ramp gradually. Year 1 averages 50 covers per day across a slow start. Year 2 reaches 70 as the brand builds. Year 3 hits 85, which represents roughly 70% of maximum capacity.

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Operating Days	250	250	250
Average Daily Covers	50	70	85
Average Spend per Cover	£42	£44	£46
Annual Revenue	£525,000	£770,000	£977,500
Cost of Goods Sold (26.4%)	£138,600	£203,280	£258,060
Gross Profit	£386,400	£566,720	£719,440
Operating Costs	£456,600	£475,000	£495,000
Net Profit (Loss)	(£70,200)	£91,720	£224,440

Year 1 shows a loss of £70,200. That is expected. New bars take time to build their audience, and fixed costs (particularly rent and staff) run from day one regardless of covers. Monthly break-even falls around Month 7 to 8, when average daily covers reach approximately 59 (the point at which monthly revenue exceeds monthly total costs).

Year 2 turns profitable at £91,720. Year 3 reaches £224,440 as covers grow and slight price increases take effect.

Cost of goods sold runs at a blended 26.4% of revenue. That reflects 25% on drinks and 30% on food. Both figures are in line with London bar industry benchmarks. The operating cost base is detailed in the accompanying financial model.

Startup Costs

Item	Estimated Cost
Lease deposit and legal fees	£35,000
Steampunk interior fitout	£120,000
Robotic bartender units (x2, with custom casing)	£80,000
Bar equipment, POS, kitchen	£35,000
Initial stock (drinks and food)	£12,000
Licensing, insurance, PRS/PPL	£6,000
Marketing launch	£12,000
Working capital (3 months)	£20,000
Total	£320,000

14. Operations and Staffing

The bar operates Tuesday to Saturday. Tuesday to Thursday from 5pm to midnight. Friday and Saturday from 5pm to 2am. Sunday and Monday closed.

The staffing model is lean. The robots handle cocktail production, which reduces the need for multiple skilled bartenders. The team is structured as follows.

Role	Number	Notes
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General Manager	1	Full-time, oversees all operations
Bar Supervisor	1	Manages robot operation, quality control, stock
Bar Staff	3	Order taking, beer/wine service, customer interaction
Kitchen Staff	2	Tapas preparation and plating
Host	1	Door, bookings, table management
Total	8	Estimated monthly payroll of £21,000

Staff wear period-inspired attire. Waistcoats, pocket watches, goggles as accessories. The costume is part of the experience but should be comfortable enough for a full shift. A costume allowance is included in the fitout budget.

Suppliers include a spirits distributor (for the core cocktail range), a local craft brewery (for rotating guest beers), a food supplier for tapas ingredients, and the robotic unit manufacturer for parts and servicing. All supplier relationships should be established during the pre-launch phase.

15. Marketing Strategy

The bar markets itself. That is not laziness. It is a genuine strategic advantage. A robotic bartender making cocktails inside a steampunk Victorian interior is inherently shareable content. Every guest with a phone becomes a marketer. The strategy leans into this.

Pre-launch, the focus is building anticipation. A teaser campaign on Instagram and TikTok showing the build-out, the robot installation, and the interior taking shape. A launch event for press, influencers, and local food and drink bloggers. A soft launch period with reduced pricing to fill the room and generate early reviews.

Post-launch, the ongoing strategy has four components. First, organic social media. The robot mixing drinks is the content. Staff create short-form video daily. Second, listings and reviews. The bar should be listed on DesignMyNight, Time Out, Google, and TripAdvisor within the first month, with active review management. Third, partnerships. Collaborate with local Shoreditch businesses, hotels, and event organisers for cross-promotion. Fourth, The Boiler Room. The unlimited package is itself a marketing tool. Groups book it, share it, and bring friends back.

Marketing budget is £2,000 per month ongoing, plus a £12,000 launch campaign. The expectation is that organic reach will exceed paid reach within three months, given the visual nature of the concept.

16. Risk Analysis

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Robot malfunction or downtime	Medium	High	Maintain service contract with manufacturer. Train bar staff to make cocktails manually as backup. Keep two units so one can cover if the other is offline.
Slow initial footfall	Medium	High	Budget for a 6 to 9 month ramp. Working capital covers 3 months of losses. Adjust marketing spend if month 3 is below 35 covers per day.
Rising rent	Medium	Medium	Negotiate a 3 to 5 year lease with capped annual increases. Shoreditch rents are high but have stabilised in recent years.

Novelty wear-off	Medium	Medium	Rotate signature cocktail menu quarterly. Introduce seasonal themes. Vary live music acts. The Boiler Room creates habit-forming repeat visits.
Licensing refusal	Low	High	Engage a licensing solicitor early. The premises licence for alcohol and late-night refreshment is standard for Shoreditch. Music licence (PRS/PPL) is straightforward.
Food hygiene issues	Low	High	Hire experienced kitchen staff. Achieve 5-star food hygiene rating before launch. Standard HACCP procedures for tapas preparation.
Competition opens similar concept	Low	Medium	First-mover advantage matters in themed bars. Build the brand and loyal customer base before imitators arrive. The steampunk fitout and robot investment create a high barrier to entry.
Staff retention	Medium	Medium	Pay above London living wage. Offer a share of tips. Create a culture that staff enjoy being part of. The costume and theme make the job more fun than a standard bar role.

17. Pilot Launch Strategy

The Brass Automaton launches with a single venue in Shoreditch. This is a pilot, not a chain. The first 12 months are about proving the model works before thinking about expansion.

The launch follows three phases.

Phase 1 (Months 1 to 4). Setup. Register the company as a limited company. Secure the venue lease. Begin the steampunk fitout. Order and install the robotic bartender units. Apply for premises licence, alcohol licence, and PRS/PPL music licence. Hire the general manager and bar supervisor. Build the pre-launch social media presence.

Phase 2 (Months 5 to 6). Soft launch. Complete the fitout. Hire remaining staff. Run a 2 to 4 week soft launch with reduced pricing, invited guests, and press events. Test the robot operation under real conditions. Refine the menu based on early feedback. Iron out operational issues before the public opening.

Phase 3 (Months 7 to 12). Grand opening and growth. Open to the public with full marketing push. Introduce The Boiler Room unlimited package. Launch the live music programme. Focus on building reviews, repeat visits, and organic social media reach. Target 70 covers per day by month 10 to 12.

A decision on Phase 2 expansion (second venue, robotic waiters, or geographic expansion) will be made at the 18-month mark, based on financial performance, customer feedback, and operational stability. No expansion commitment is made before the pilot is proven.